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Where Theology and Non-Dualism Dance: Analyzing the Immanent Divine in Hopkins's "God's Grandeur"

The tension between human action and divine force has long been widely discussed through religions, art, and literature. Gerard Manley Hopkins's "God's Grandeur," for me, is one of the best examples when it comes to this topic. Structured as a Petrarchan sonnet, the poem uses dense sonic textures to highlight a paradox: despite humanity's attempts to detach itself from the natural world, divine energy continues to sustain it. As someone who has been surrounded by Eastern philosophy and ideology all my life, this poem linked my thinking to Daoism and Prana. It made me realise that divinity is not a distant entity that we can't reach, but an immanent presence in our world that is only obscured by the ignorance of humans.

In the first eight lines, Hopkins establishes god's presence in our world, then turns to a critique of how humans separated from that world. Hopkins opens with an absolute declaration: "The world is charged with the grandeur of God" (Hopkins 1). The word 'charged' is used as a metaphor of electrical energy, suggesting that the universe acts as a battery full of divine power. In Eastern philosophy, this 'charge' is like Qi or Prana, the vital life force that animates the cosmos. This energy is also illustrated through two contrasting similes. First, it "will flame out, like shining from shook foil" (Hopkins 2). describes the sudden flash of divine revelation that occurs when the world is examined. Second, "It gathers to a greatness, like the ooze of oil / Crushed" (Hopkins 3-4). This implies that the image changes from something sudden to

something slow, showing that God's essence can appear both quickly and gradually, and that it is deep and powerful.

Besides this declaration, the poem's tone changes to critique human blindness. Hopkins asks, "Why do men then now not reckon his rod?" (Hopkins 4). This rhetorical question points out the concept of spiritual ignorance. In Advaita Vedanta, this condition is known as Maya, the illusion that the material world is the ultimate reality. Hopkins emphasizes the repetitive trap of this illusion through repetition and internal rhyme: "Generations have trod, have trod, have trod" (Hopkins 5). The heavy rhythm mirrors the mechanical march of industrialization and the hardship of human labor.

The impact of this industrial mindset is powerful: "And all is seared with trade; bleared, smeared with toil" (Hopkins 6). Through the heavy consonance and the assonance of the "eared" sound, Hopkins creates an auditory representation of the world being tired and exhausted. The natural surface of the earth now "wears man's smudge and shares man's smell" (Hopkins 7). This feeling of separation reaches its peak in the physical distance between humans and nature: "the soil / Is bare now, nor can foot feel, being shod" (Hopkins 7-8). The shoe becomes a metaphor for the artificial barriers humanity builds, cutting off their direct physical connection to the Earth and to the divine reality beneath it.

Despite the bleakness of the first eight lines, the poem changes dramatically at the volta, marking the beginning of the last 6 lines. Hopkins declares, "And for all this, nature is never spent" (Hopkins 9). This line asserts the indestructible nature of the divine presence. In Daoism, the Dao is often described as a well that is used but never used up, an inexhaustible source that generates and sustains all forms. Hopkins echoes this exact philosophy: beneath the "bleared" surface of the human world lies a wellspring of renewal.

He locates this renewal in the depths of existence: “There lives the dearest freshness deep down things” (Hopkins 10). The use of alliteration in “dearest,” “deep,” and “down” draws the reader’s focus inward and downward, moving away from the superficial “smudge” of the surface into the ontological core of reality. This “freshness” is the reality, the pure block of Eastern thought, entirely untouched by human corruption.

Hopkins then further explains this cycle through the image of the changing from day to night: “A“And though the last lights off the black West went / Oh, morning, at the brown brink eastward, springs—” (Hopkins 11-12). Hopkins uses enjambment as the line spills eastward, mimicking the inevitable rise of the sun. Additionally, the setting of the sun in the “black West” symbolizes spiritual darkness and human decline, but the rising in the East represents an eternal, cosmic rebirth powered by the divine.

The poem concludes by revealing the source of this continuous renewal: “B“Because the Holy Ghost over the bent / World broods with warm breast and with ah! bright wings” (Hopkins 13-14). In these final lines, Hopkins utilizes his signature “sprung rhythm” to break the confines of traditional meter, using the exclamation “ah!” to force a pause of pure wonder and awe. The image of the Holy Ghost as a mother bird brooding over a nest transforms the distorted world into a child under the warm care of divinity.

When reading this final metaphor, my thoughts became a common playground where Western theology and Eastern non-dualism dance and play together. The divine is not situated in a distant heaven, but is intimately wrapped around the fragile world, sustaining it with a protective, maternal energy. The “bright wings” offer a final contrast to the “black West” and the “smudge” of human toil, returning to the flashing, electrical grandeur of the opening line. Ultimately, Hopkins stated that through poetic craft, while human actions may obscure the

surface of the world, the underlying reality remains ever-present, protective, and eternally vibrant.

Work cited

Hopkins, Gerard Manley. "God's Grandeur." *Poetry Foundation*,
www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/44395/gods-grandeur.